clarity about the post-2014 Afghan political landscape gave credence to this argument. According to a high-ranking MEA official, 'Kabul's wish list keeps on growing every time and before committing to anything we have to keep the larger regional interest and peace in mind.'[135] Differences existed between Manmohan Singh, a conciliator, and Narayanan, a partisan, on issues related to Pakistan and, by corollary, Afghanistan.[136] But as the PM, Singh reigned supreme. India's political leadership as well as the MEA, despite accepting the need to develop Afghanistan's capacities to counter Pakistan-sponsored anti-state actors, was comfortable with soft power decisions. This was because, as the conciliators argued, a soft power approach may not help achieving certain goals in Afghanistan, but it would surely not jeopardise India's long-term interests in the region.

The conciliators were derided as 'peace-*wallahs*' (peacenicks). Such terms reverberated with the old British debates where the closed border school was disparaged as 'masterly inactivity' and the forward school was ridiculed as 'mischievous activity'. In 2013, allegedly, these 'peace-*wallahs*' pushed the PMO to not supply weapons to Afghanistan. They argued that if stabilising relations with Pakistan was India's strategic aim then engagement with Afghanistan should be reduced, especially as the latter is not even in New Delhi's immediate strategic circuit. An editorial in the *Indian Express* advocated a conciliatory position (as opposed to the *ToI's* partisan stand) as such:

> While Delhi has offered to enhance its contribution to Afghan reconstruction, it must move forward more carefully on arms supply. India needs to balance its stakes in Afghanistan against the potential reaction from Pakistan and the NATO. The Pakistan army is indispensable for peace in Afghanistan—it is also the problem. Moreover, Karzai's visit to India coincided with increased skirmishes along the Durand Line.[137]

The powerful former Editor-in-Chief of the *Indian Express*, Shekhar Gupta, who had actively reported from Afghanistan in the early 1990s, was even more blunt in saying, 'get out, leave Af to Pak'.[138] Scathing in his critique of the partisans, Gupta stated that 'engaging in a policy that puts us [India] permanently and, inevitably, violently at odds with the Pakistanis is an idea that is being accepted much too readily. As if this is our destiny, part of an ongoing blood feud. As if we have no choice. All of this, frankly, is lazy, self-serving rubbish, dished